ONLINE SAFETY IN DIGITAL ENVIRONMENT

A PARENT'S GUIDE TO ONLINE SAFETY

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Online Safety in Digital Environments

A Guide for Parents

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1. Introduction

Online games are a central part of many children's daily lives. They are not just games—they are interactive social environments where players communicate, compete, and build relationships in real time, often across countries and cultures.

For many children and young people, gaming is a primary space for social interaction. They may spend time with friends, join online communities, and participate in shared experiences that extend beyond the game itself. While these environments can support creativity, collaboration, and a sense of belonging, they also introduce new challenges.

Children may interact with strangers, encounter different communication styles, and be exposed to behaviours or content they do not fully understand. Many games also include systems such as in-game purchases, reward mechanics, and continuous engagement features, which can influence how children play and spend time online. At the same time, personal information may be shared—intentionally or unintentionally—without full awareness of the potential consequences.

This guide provides parents and guardians with a clear and practical overview of the digital gaming environment. It explains key concepts such as age ratings, communication culture, digital footprints, and microtransactions, and highlights areas where children may need guidance and support.

The goal is not to judge games as good or bad, but to help parents understand how these environments work. With greater awareness, parents can make informed decisions, set appropriate boundaries, and have open, constructive conversations with their children about their gaming experiences.

2. Age Rating (PEGI)

Age ratings help show whether a game is suitable for a certain age group. They are based on factors such as violence, language, frightening content, gambling-like mechanics, and online interactions. However, ratings do not account for differences in children's maturity or behaviour in online environments.

PEGI (Pan European Game Information) classifies games into the age categories 3, 7, 12, 16, and 18 based on their content and themes.

Age	Description
3+	Simple and educational games with little or no violence
7+	Mild suspense or limited violence that does not appear realistic
12+	Greater complexity and some action elements. Violence may be more visible, but it is still not highly realistic.
16+	Stronger or more realistic violence, with intense and competitive elements
18+	Games intended for adults, featuring explicit and often graphic violence, strong language, or sexual content

Age ratings are a useful tool that helps put video games into context and provides insight into the types of content a game may include. They can be an important guideline when assessing which games are suitable for children and young people, but it is important to remember that individual experiences can vary.

3. Digital Footprint

In digital environments, it is important to keep in mind that everything shared online becomes part of a digital footprint. Over time, these traces accumulate and form an overall picture. Individual pieces of content may seem harmless when viewed on their own, but when combined, they can provide clearer insight into a person. This may relate to interests, habits, relationships, and communication. In this way, small pieces of information can build a larger picture of how an individual behaves online.

Once someone shares content online, they cannot always control what happens next, and it may remain accessible longer than expected. It is therefore important to think carefully before sharing anything and to remember that even seemingly harmless content can have consequences later.

Awareness of one's digital footprint is important. It helps in understanding how online behaviour impacts and supports responsible use. With greater knowledge, it becomes easier to make informed decisions. Every post and every message leaves a trace.

3.1. Personal Information

It is important to understand what counts as personal information and not share it online. This includes information such as a full name, age, and home address that identify a person in real life.

It is also important to be aware that usernames can reveal such information, for example, if they include a name, birth year, or location. It is essential to understand the difference between harmless information, such as a favourite colour or hobbies, and sensitive information that may affect personal safety. Therefore, it is important to regularly discuss what is appropriate to share and what is not, and to pay attention to the choice of usernames.

3.2. Privacy

Privacy involves controlling how people share personal information and who can access it. In online games and apps, settings often determine who can view information, contact players, or monitor activity within the gaming environment.

It is important to review these settings and choose appropriate restrictions on access and communication. Unrestricted access can increase the likelihood of unwanted interactions, so managing access is essential. It is also important to be aware of what information is visible to others on social media profiles or gaming accounts.

Parents should regularly discuss privacy and teach how to protect personal information. This includes setting access controls, accepting connections only from known individuals, and being mindful of what they share and with whom.

3.3. Online Communication

Online communication takes place within games, on websites, and in communication apps such as Discord and Twitch. In these spaces, interactions often occur between strangers and may be anonymous. In such situations, the risk of personal information being shared increases.

Scams and phishing can also occur in these environments, where others may try to trick users into providing information, for example, by offering rewards or gifts. Young users may be particularly vulnerable to this, making it important to discuss these risks and encourage caution in communication.

It is important to understand the privacy settings of the communication platforms that players use. These settings allow users to control who can access their information, which groups they join, and who they communicate with. Closed groups, where only approved members can join, can also increase safety and provide better oversight of usage.

4. Cyberbullying and communication culture in online gaming

Online games are social environments where communication is quick and direct. Players may chat via text or voice, send private messages, and interact with people they do not know in real life. Because of anonymity and competition, communication can sometimes become more intense, and frustration may be expressed more openly.

4.1 Understanding Risks: Cyberbullying in Games

Cyberbullying in games can take different forms, including insults or offensive comments, repeated criticism or blaming, exclusion from teams or group activities, and derogatory language directed at individuals or groups. These behaviours can have real consequences for a child's well-being and self-esteem, especially when they occur repeatedly.

4.2 Signs to Watch For

Some signs may indicate that a child is experiencing negative interactions or cyberbullying. A child may become irritated, upset, or withdrawn while playing, avoid talking about their gaming experiences, or suddenly stop playing a game they previously enjoyed. They may also mention being teased, criticised, or excluded.

4.3 What Parents Can Do

Parents can start open conversations by asking who their child plays with and how communication feels during the game. It is important to normalise speaking up by making it clear that negative behaviour from others is not something they have to accept. Parents can also use in-game tools together with their child, showing them how to mute, block, or report other players. In addition, setting clear expectations for respectful communication, even during competition, helps reinforce positive behaviour.

5. Microtransactions and Digital Payments

Microtransactions are small digital payments that players can make within video games to obtain items or services. These may include cosmetic changes and decorations, virtual currency, temporary access, or other digital features. In some cases, such purchases only affect appearance, while in others, they may influence game progression or a player's ability to achieve better results.

Developers often design these systems to extend a game's lifespan and increase user engagement. When elements such as uncertainty, collectables, or time-limited opportunities shape the experience, they can also have psychological effects on players. Understanding the different types of microtransactions and the structure of digital payment systems is, therefore, an important part of digital literacy and supports informed decision-making.

5.1. Cosmetic Items and Customisation (e.g. skins)

This type of microtransaction includes items that change a character's or equipment's appearance in the game without affecting performance. This can include skins, outfits, colours, dances (emotes), and other decorative items that make the gaming experience more personal. For many players, these are fun and optional ways to enhance the game visually without changing the gameplay itself.

Examples of games where this is especially common include ***F****ortnite, Valorant, Roblo****x***, and others.

5.2. Time Boosts

Time boosts are purchases that allow players to progress more quickly. These may include reduced waiting times, bonus levels, or faster development that would otherwise take longer to achieve. This can benefit players who have less time to play, but it can also create differences between those who pay and those who do not.

Young players must understand that these are optional purchases and should not be necessary to enjoy the game.

Examples: *Clash Royale, Candy Crush, Royal Match, and FIFA/EA FC Ultimate Team.*

5.3. Loot Boxes

Loot boxes are a type of microtransaction where players pay for content without knowing exactly what they will receive. They open boxes or packs containing random rewards, ranging from common to rare.

This can resemble gambling, and children need to understand that the outcome is uncertain and often unpredictable. Players should approach these types of purchases with caution, as the uncertainty about the contents can easily lead to overspending.

Examples: *Counter-Strike 2, FIFA/EA FC, and Apex Legends.*

5.4. Virtual Currency Systems

Many games use a specific in-game currency that players must buy before they can purchase items. Developers often sell this currency in bundles, even when an item costs only a portion of the bundle. As a result, players often end up with leftover currency that they cannot spend without making additional purchases.

This can lead to higher spending than intended, so it is important for parents and young players to be aware of this system and to discuss purchases together.

Examples: *Fortnite (V-Bucks), Roblox (Robux), League of Legends (Riot Points), and FIFA/EA FC (FIFA Points).*

5.5. Battle Pass

Battle passes are subscription-based systems that give players access to special rewards over a set period. Once players purchase the pass, it unlocks new challenges and content that they can earn through regular gameplay.

This can be an engaging way to extend a game's lifespan, but children need to understand that the pass is valid only for a limited time and that they must renew it to maintain access.

Examples: *Fortnite, Apex Legends, Call of Duty, and Rocket League.*

5.6. Pay-to-Win.

This type of microtransaction involves players purchasing items or bonuses that help them achieve better results more quickly. This may include becoming stronger, faster, or skipping certain levels in the game. Examples include increased abilities, bonus levels, better equipment, or other enhancements that have a direct impact on a player's performance.

Pay-to-win mechanics are particularly common in mobile games, where players can purchase time boosts and performance enhancements that directly affect their standing in the game.

6. Overview – Green/Yellow/Red System

Online games can vary in structure, communication, and the features they offer. Some games are simple and self-contained, while others include active interaction with other players, digital payments, or competitive systems that can affect the user experience.

To help parents better understand the type of gaming environment their children are in, we can use a simple green, yellow, red system to describe games. This system is not a formal age rating, but rather a way to put the gaming experience into context and support conversations between parents and children about how a game works.

The colours primarily reflect how complex the game's social and digital environment is, not whether the game is good or bad.

🟢 Green

Games with limited communication and little or no purchasing elements. In these games, interaction with other players is minimal or non-existent, and the focus is on entertainment, creativity, or simple tasks. Making it easier for younger users to understand and manage.

An example of a game that falls into the green category is **Minecraft**, when played alone or in a private world with friends.

🟡 Yellow

Games with active communication and the possibility of microtransactions. In these games, players can communicate with others via text or voice chat and may purchase digital content, such as cosmetic items, virtual currency, or other features.

These games can be highly social and enjoyable, but also require awareness of communication, digital footprints, and in-game purchases.

An example of a game that falls into the yellow category is ***Roblox***, which features player interaction and a digital currency for in-game purchases.

🔴Red

Games with open communication, more complex purchasing systems, or highly competitive pressure. In these games, interaction with other players can be open and may involve large groups of users that the child does not know.

These games may also include features such as ranking systems, competitive tournaments, or open voice chat, making communication and competition central to the experience.

Games such as ***Fortnite, Valorant,*** and ***Overwatch*** are examples in which communication, competition, and teamwork are major parts of gameplay.

6.1. How can this help parents?

The green, yellow, red system is a way for parents to put their children's gaming experiences into context. The goal is not to ban certain games, but to better understand how they work.

The system can, for example, help parents to:

- Understand how much communication takes place in the game.
- Identify whether the game includes digital payments or purchases.
- Talk with children about behaviour and communication in games.
- Assess whether a game is appropriate for the child's age and level of maturity.

A red classification does not mean that a game is dangerous or inappropriate, but simply that it involves a more complex social environment that requires more discussion and clear boundaries.

7. Appendix

7.1. Glossary of Key Terms

Below is a glossary of common terms related to digital safety, internet use, and communication among children and young people. The aim is to create a shared language that supports discussion, understanding, and guidance in the digital world.

Digital Environment and Internet Use

- **Social media** – Apps or websites where users share photos, videos, or messages and interact with each other, for example, Instagram, TikTok, and Snapchat.
- **Streamer / Influencer** – An individual who broadcasts content live or regularly shares content online to a large audience, often to inform, entertain, or influence others.
- **Streaming** – Watching or listening to content online in real time or on demand without downloading it to a device.
- **Direct messages (DMs)** – Private messages sent between users on social media, apps, or in online games, where communication can take place without others seeing it.
- **Username** – A name used publicly online, for example, in games or on social media. It can unintentionally reveal personal information if not chosen carefully.

Responsible Online Behaviour

- **Cyberbullying** – Harassment that takes place online. It may involve insults, threats, or the spread of rumours on social media, in chats, or in games. It is often repeated behaviour.
- **Phishing** – A form of fraud aimed at stealing personal information, such as passwords or card details. This is often done through fake emails or messages that appear legitimate.
- **Grooming** – When an adult deliberately manipulates children or young people online to gain their trust and later exploit it.
- **Privacy** – The right and ability of an individual to control who collects, sees, uses, or shares their personal information, especially in digital environments.
- **Parental controls** – Tools and settings that allow parents to monitor and limit children's use of digital devices, the content they access, and the time they spend online.
- **Virus / Malware** – Harmful software that can infect devices, cause malfunctions, steal information, or monitor users without their knowledge.
- **Deepfake** – Image, video, or audio content created or altered using artificial intelligence to appear real. Such content is often used for deceptive purposes.

Behaviour and Critical Thinking

- **Misinformation / Fake news** – False or misleading content that spreads online and is presented as reliable information.
- **Algorithm** – A system that determines what content a user sees online, based on past behaviour, interests, and interactions.
- **Filter bubble** – A situation where a user mainly sees content that reinforces their existing views, often due to algorithms.
- **Viral content** – Content that spreads rapidly online and reaches a large audience, without necessarily being accurate or safe.
- **Microtransactions** – Small in-game payments for items or services. Some only affect appearance, while others can influence performance or a player's progress in the game.